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License Plate Reader Vote Angers Clawson, Mich., Police

After the City Council voted not to renew a contract for the devices, two police officers threatened to quit. Residents spoke against the renewal and the motion failed on a 3-3 vote.

May 12, 2026 • Kara Berg, The Detroit News

A license plate reading camera on Jefferson Ave. in downtown Detroit, March 26, 2026.
David Guralnick, Detroit News/TNS

(TNS) — Two Clawson police officers threatened to quit their jobs at a City Council meeting last week after the board voted not to renew the city's contract for license plate readers.

Clawson, an Oakland County suburb with about 11,500 residents, had had a contract with Flock Safety for license plate readers at four points in the city.

But at an hours-long meeting last week, several residents from Clawson and outside of the city spoke against renewing the contract. Some raised privacy concerns; others were concerned about the lack of control the city would have over the footage once it's collected.

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After the vote by the council against renewing the contract, Clawson Sgt. Paul Korb said he was considering leaving the department. The department's school resource officer, Lindsay Brozich, walked up to the podium and slapped her badge down, leaving it there as she walked away.

"I believe, I don't know for sure, that you just lost your school resource officer, and I am also considering leaving," Korb said.

Clawson Police Chief Kellie Bauss declined to say whether Korb or any other officers had left her department over the council's decision, saying she couldn't comment on personnel matters. But she said the department "respects the City Council's role in making decisions on behalf of the community."

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License plate readers are publicly mounted cameras that capture images of the rear of vehicles and their license plates to assist police in solving crimes or locating missing people. They've become nearly ubiquitous across Metro Detroit in the last four years.

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As of April, more than 180 law enforcement agencies statewide — nearly a third of all agencies in Michigan — now use Flock Safety technology, according to data compiled by the company, which is the most prominent license plate reader vendor in the country. Of the state's five largest cities — Detroit, Grand Rapids, Warren, Sterling Heights and Ann Arbor — only Ann Arbor doesn't use the license plate reader technology, although the University of Michigan does.

In an email to *The Detroit News*, Bauss said while there may be differing opinions regarding public safety technology, "our mission and commitment to delivering high-quality police services to our residents, business owners, and visitors remains unchanged. I want to recognize the dedication and professionalism of the men and women of this department," Bauss said in an email. "Our officers come to work every day dedicated to protecting this community, often under difficult and highly scrutinized circumstances."

MOTION FAILED AFTER 3-3 VOTE

The motion to renew the city's contract with Flock was tied 3-3, resulting in its failure and the nonrenewal of the contract. Councilmembers Meredith Peltonen, Laura Slowinski and Alec Speshock voted against the renewal of the contract, while Mayor Susan Moffitt, Mayor Pro Tem Aidan O'Rourke and Councilmember Scott Tinlin voted in favor of it.

"This is really tough, because we do trust you, Chief Bauss, and all of your police officers," Slowinski said. "It's just, the information I've heard isn't just from the people who are here tonight. ... It's tough because of this not being able to control the data."

Moffitt said this is a "very, very difficult conversation" for the council. She noted she doesn't want to take tools away from the police department, but also wants to respect the community that has concerns about the technology.

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CHIEF: FLOCK CAMERAS AREN'T A SURVEILLANCE TOOL

Bauss said at the City Council meeting that Flock is not a surveillance method, but is a tool used in response to a crime or a missing person. She said she's heard from business owners who are in support of it, but don't want to speak out for fear of public pushback.

"This technology is essential to law enforcement," Bauss said. "The benefits outweigh the potential concerns. ... It advances our ability to solve crimes that oftentimes we might not have the ability to solve."

Bauss cited examples of when they and other departments have successfully used Flock to arrest a suspect, including during mass casualty events, finding a missing person in need of immediate help during a mental health crisis, finding a suspect in a stabbing and locating a bank robbery suspect.

Brozich said before the vote that it is frustrating to think about Flock being removed from their set of tools.

"I have loved serving the community I grew up in but this is both frustrating and disheartening," Brozich said. "I feel like don't have support from the community to perform a hard job. ... It is difficult to have tools taken away while also being expected to respond quickly and solve complex cases in a timely manner while being scrutinized for it."

More: [Troy extends license plate reader contract](#)

O'Rourke expressed concern that Clawson would be one of two cities in Oakland County — Ferndale being the other — that would not have access to Flock. He said

this is an essential tool for the police department and "taking away a tool like this is not what we should be doing to city officials."

"I could defend a yes," O'Rourke said. "But I would struggle to defend a 'no' to the next victim of a crime we could not solve."

Michigan doesn't have any laws regulating LPR data storage or the transparency of its use with the public. State Rep. Doug Wozniak, a Shelby Township Republican, has introduced a bipartisan bill that would require police agencies to publish their LPR logs and delete the cameras' data after a certain period of time.

Reporter Max Bryan contributed to this story.

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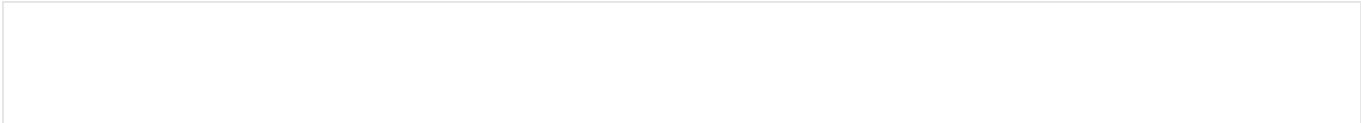
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